

China: Growth weakened despite activity stabilization

Production steadies, domestic demand drags

Extel - 2026

Global Fixed Income Research Survey

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- 2Q GDP slowed to 4.3%oya; sequential momentum weakened.
- June IP stabilized, led by equipment and high-tech manufacturing.
- FAI remained the main drag, led by property and private investment.
- Retail sales improved, but household demand stayed soft.
- We lower 2026 real GDP growth to 4.6%/y on weaker demand/external risks, but lift 3Q/4Q to 4.3%/4.9%q/q saar on stronger fiscal support.
- Policy must turn fiscal resources into domestic demand to support 2H growth.

June activity stabilization reduced the risk of an immediate slide, but 2Q GDP confirmed a weaker and more uneven growth path. Production stabilized and retail sales improved modestly, while investment remained weak. Exports, industrial upgrading and policy-supported production are cushioning activity, but housing, investment and household demand continue to weigh on domestic absorption.

Real GDP slowed to 4.3%oya in 2Q from 5.0% in 1Q (vs JPM: 4.7%oya; consensus: 4.5%oya), with sequential growth easing to 2.4%q/q saar (vs JPM: 3.3%). Manufacturing and services remained resilient: secondary industry grew 3.0%oya despite property weakness, while tertiary industry rose 5.1%, with June services production up 4.7%. Net trade likely cushioned growth, though fast-rising imports may have reduced the contribution; investment was the main drag and consumption offered only modest support. Growth support has narrowed towards external demand, services and selected production.

Production stabilized in June. IP rose 5.3%oya, up from 4.5% in May (vs JPM and consensus: 4.6%), with sequential growth picking up to 1.0%m/m sa. In 1H, industrial value added rose 5.4%oya and manufacturing grew 5.6%, while equipment and high-tech manufacturing outperformed at 9.3% and 13.3%. Together with June PMIs, this suggests production may have found a floor, but mainly in the external-demand, equipment and high-tech segments.

Investment remained the main drag. FAI fell 10.0%oya in June and 5.7%ytd (vs JPM: -5.4%ytd; consensus: -5.0%ytd) in 1H. Real estate FAI contracted 18.0%ytd; manufacturing investment fell 1.2%ytd, infrastructure declined 2.4%ytd, and private FAI dropped 8.5%ytd. Innovation-related capex was more resilient: intellectual property-product investment rose 9.4% and high-tech industry investment 4.6%—but too narrow to offset weak property, traditional manufacturing and public works.

Consumption offered only a limited cushion. Retail sales rose 1.0%oya in June to CNY 4.27trn after falling 0.6% in May (vs JPM: 0.1%oya; consensus: -0.1%),

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helped by a 0.4% m/m sa rebound. In 1H, retail sales grew only 1.3% oya to CNY 24.9trn; services retail rose 5.3%, versus goods retail at 1.1%, and online goods and services sales grew 5.2%. Services and online channels were more resilient, but autos, fading trade-in effects and housing-related categories remained weak.

Trade remained a cushion, not a growth engine. In June, goods trade rose 24.2% oya, with exports up 20.8% and imports up 29.4%; in 1H, exports grew 13.4% and imports 22.1%. Mechanical and electrical exports rose 20.1% in 1H and accounted for 63.5% of total exports, consistent with the AI/electronics cycle. This supports production stabilization, but fast import growth and concentrated export strength suggest trade can cushion the slowdown, not deliver growth on its own.

External challenges meet weak absorption

The growth impulse remains narrow. External demand, trade rerouting, the global AI/IP cycle and policy-supported production are supporting activity, but spillovers to jobs, income and household demand are limited. The result is a two-speed economy: resilient production alongside weak consumption, cautious private investment, a still-adjusting housing sector and slow fiscal execution.

Risks are building on both fronts. Externally, renewed Middle East tensions raise energy, shipping and commodity-cost risks; the US is rebuilding tariff walls through Section 301/232 tools and sector restrictions; a September Trump-Xi summit may stabilize relations tactically but not resolve structural disputes; and Europe adds pressure around EVs, batteries, solar and subsidies. Domestically, weak housing, cautious firms and constrained local governments reduce fiscal multipliers and increase the risk that production resilience turns into inventories, price competition, margin pressure and disinflation.

Policy needs to shift from supply-side to absorption. The priority is faster fiscal execution: drawing down deposits, front-loading special bonds, expanding policy-bank and central-government financing, and pushing funds into projects with clear demand, productivity gains, and private-sector participation. Housing policy should focus on completion, inventory absorption, urban renewal and buyer confidence. Monetary easing can help at the margin, but without stronger credit demand, rate cuts would be more signal than stimulus.

The July Politburo meeting is likely to reinforce faster fiscal deployment, domestic demand support, and stabilization of employment, enterprises, markets and expectations. The key test is whether policy can turn available funding into activity, otherwise it will remain a buffer rather than a turnaround. The *15th Five-Year Plan for Expanding Consumption*, released on July 13 by the NDRC and Ministry of Commerce, is directionally positive but short on implementation details and explicit, targeted fiscal deployment. It aims for retail sales of around CNY 60trn by 2030, up from CNY 50.1trn in 2025, and emphasizes services, digital and green consumption, AI-plus-consumption, consumer infrastructure, income growth and social security. As with past initiatives, the risk is that a consumption plan becomes state-guided, supply-side oriented and infrastructure-heavy, limiting its ability to generate genuine household demand.

Our outlook remains for managed stabilization, not a decisive rebound. We have lowered our full-year real GDP forecast to 4.6%/y/y from 4.7%, reflecting weaker domestic demand and a tougher external environment. At the same time, we revise up sequential growth to 4.3%/q/q saar in 3Q and 4.9% in 4Q, from 3.5% and 3.7%, respectively. The 3Q upgrade reflects likely stronger fiscal delivery after the 2Q undershoot, while the 4Q upgrade assumes possible additional out-of-budget support to keep 2026 growth within the 4.5–5.0% target range. Even so, the growth cushion remains narrow: external demand and industrial upgrading are still doing the heavy lifting, while domestic absorption is too weak to sustain a broader recovery.

Table: China GDP forecast revision

	2026	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26f	4Q26f
%q/q, saar					
Old		6.3	2.4	3.5	3.7
New				4.3	4.9
%oya					
Old	4.7	5.0	4.3	4.7	4.3
New	4.6			4.5	4.5

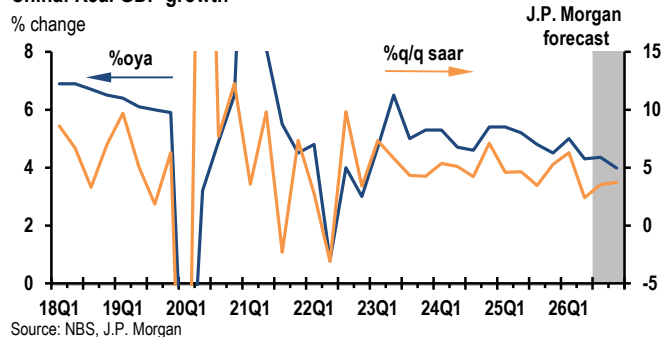
Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

China: monthly indicators

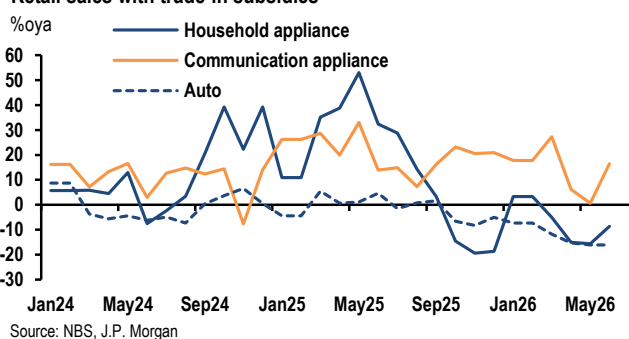
	2025	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
Real industrial production					
%oya	5.9	5.7	4.1	4.5	5.3
% change compared to same period in 2019		48.1	32.7	32.4	39.1
m/m, sa (JPM)		0.2	-1.0	0.4	1.0
m/m, sa (NBS)		0.3	0.1	0.4	0.8
Fixed asset investment					
Value					
%oya, ytd	-3.8	1.7	-1.6	-4.1	-5.7
%oya		1.6	-8.0	-10.7	-10.0
% change compared to same period in 2019		48.8	16.5	7.3	8.6
m/m, sa (JPM)		-1.4	-10.5	-2.2	-1.2
m/m, sa (NBS)		-0.8	-3.0	-1.3	-0.4
Retail Sales					
Value					
%oya	3.7	1.7	0.2	-0.6	1.0
% change compared to same period in 2019		59.0	33.5	29.6	28.6
m/m, sa (JPM)		0.0	-0.1	-0.1	0.4
m/m, sa (NBS)		0.1	-0.3	-0.2	0.4

Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

China: Real GDP growth

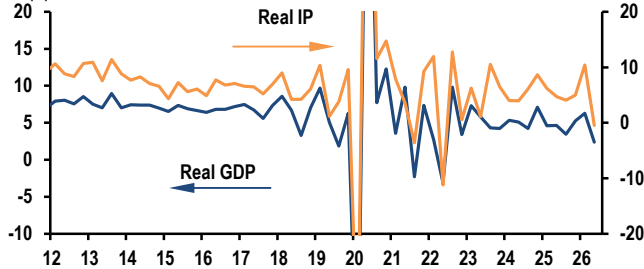


Retail sales with trade-in subsidies



China real GDP and IP

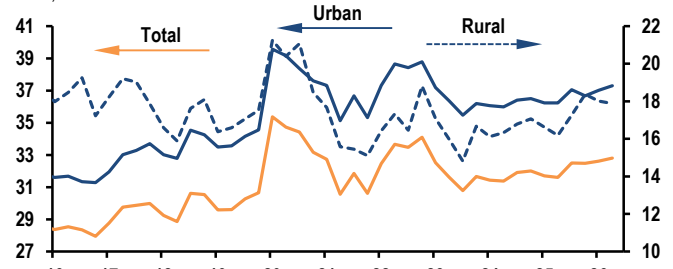
%q/q saar, both scales



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

China households saving rate

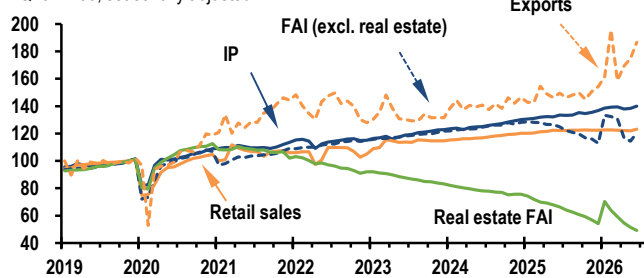
% sa, both scales



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

Key economic indicators in China

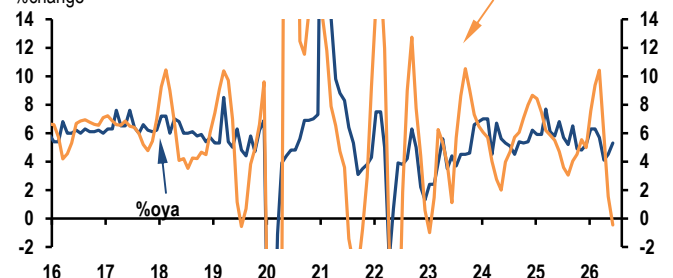
4Q19 = 100, seasonally adjusted



Source: NBS, China Customs, J.P. Morgan

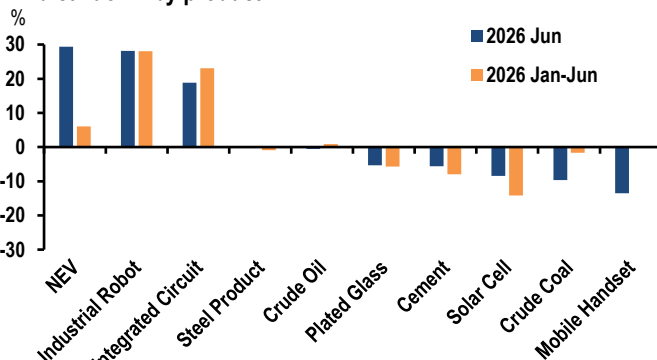
China industrial production

%change



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

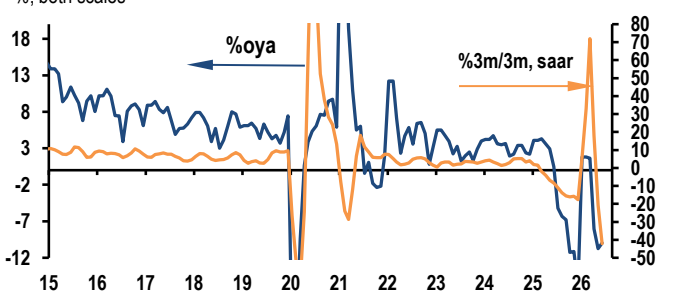
IP breakdown by product



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

China: nominal fixed asset investment growth

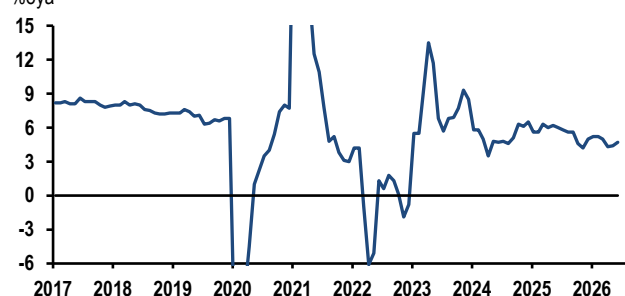
%, both scales



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

China: Service production index

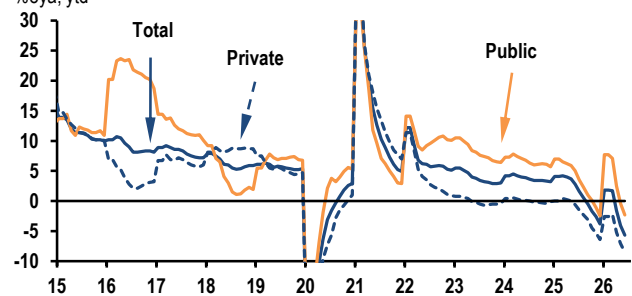
%oya



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

FAI growth: Public vs private sectors

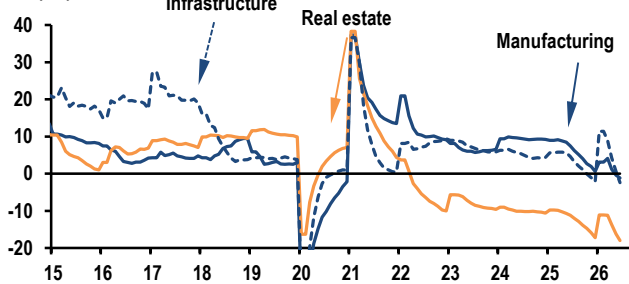
%oya, ytd



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

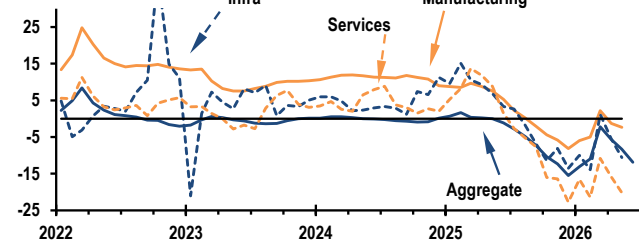
China FAI growth by industry

%oya, ytd



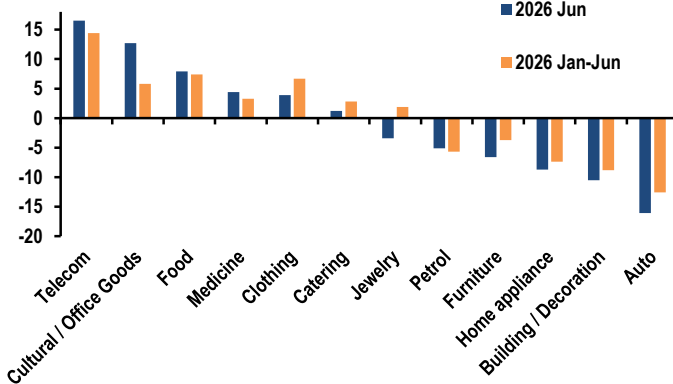
China: Private investment

%oya, 3mma



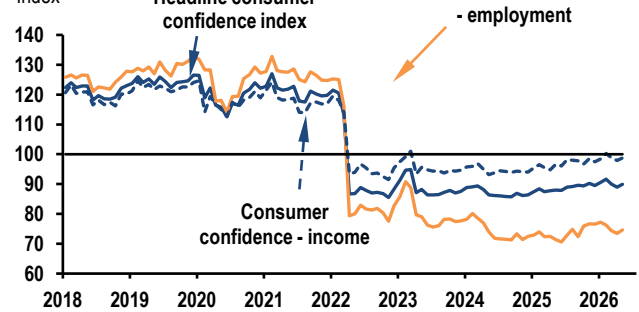
Retail sales growth breakdown

%



China consumer confidence index

Index



China fixed assets investment by industry

%oya, ytd

	% share (2025)	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
Total fixed investment	100.0	1.7	-1.6	-4.1	-5.7
Manufacturing	37.9	4.1	1.2	-0.4	-1.2
Infrastructure	30.1	8.9	4.3	0.6	-2.4
- Electricity, gas & water production and supply	8.4	9.0	4.4	-0.1	-2.7
- Transport infrastructure	10.6	16.3	11.1	7.1	2.6
- Water conservation, environment manag.	11.1	3.6	-0.1	-3.9	-6.5
Real estate	10.1	-11.2	-13.7	-16.2	-18.0

Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

Industrial production by major industry (%oya)

	2025	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
Headline	5.9	5.7	4.1	4.5	5.3
Mining	5.6	5.7	3.8	2.3	-2.2
Manufacturing	6.4	6.0	4.0	4.4	6.0
ow:High-tech manufacturing	9.4	11.7	12.8	15.1	14.1
Chemical material & product	7.8	9.0	5.3	0.3	-0.1
Pharmaceutical	2.1	6.8	1.3	4.0	6.7
Ferrous metal smelting & pressing	4.5	1.7	1.0	1.6	3.3
Non ferrous metal smelting & pressing	6.8	0.0	-1.0	-4.5	-3.8
General equipment	8.0	6.3	5.5	6.7	9.9
Special equipment	4.3	6.2	6.2	9.1	10.0
Automobile	11.5	7.5	9.2	8.3	8.7
Rail, ship, aircraft & other transport equipment	14.0	13.3	8.2	7.4	18.2
Electric machinery & equipment	9.2	5.4	3.1	4.7	7.0
Computer, communication & other electronic equipment	10.6	12.5	15.6	17.0	15.7

Source: NBS, J.P.Morgan

Industrial production by major product (units, %oya)

	2025	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
Headline	5.9	5.7	4.1	4.5	5.3
Cement	-6.9	-21.0	-10.8	-8.1	-5.6
Plated glass	-3.0	-6.6	-7.9	-6.3	-5.3
Steel product	3.1	-2.3	-1.7	-2.8	0.0
Industrial robot	28.0	24.4	15.1	27.9	28.1
NEV	25.1	1.2	3.8	17.8	29.4
Solar cell	7.6	-20.6	-25.6	-20.4	-8.4
Mobile handset	-5.8	-8.0	-0.4	-8.4	-13.5
Integrated circuit	10.9	20.6	22.1	22.9	18.8
Crude coal	1.2	0.0	-1.0	-1.7	-9.7
Crude oil	1.5	0.2	1.2	0.5	-0.5
Processed crude oil	4.1	-2.2	-5.8	-9.1	-17.7
Sulphuric acid	4.5	6.2	-2.2	-1.6	-10.0
Chemical fibre	4.9	2.2	-3.9	-3.3	-3.8
Ethylene	6.4	6.8	-4.1	2.1	5.5

Source: NBS, J.P.Morgan

Retail sales value growth (%oya)

	% share (2025)	2025	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26
Overall		3.7	1.7	0.2	-0.6	1.0
Catering	11.6	3.2	2.9	2.2	0.6	1.2
Consumer goods	88.4	3.8	1.5	-0.1	-0.7	0.9
By product: above designated size enterprise						
Clothing & footwear	3.0	3.2	7.0	3.6	3.8	3.9
Cosmetics	0.9	5.1	8.3	4.7	2.5	12.6
Jewelry	0.7	12.8	11.7	-21.3	-8.9	-3.4
Daily-use items	1.7	6.3	4.6	3.5	1.6	3.9
Sport & recreational goods	0.3	15.7	-2.0	-8.0	-8.0	-2.2
Household electronics	2.3	11	-5.0	-15.1	-15.6	-8.7
Cultural & office goods	1.0	17.3	15.0	-6.9	-1.5	12.7
Furniture	0.4	14.6	-8.7	-10.4	-8.7	-6.6
Communication appliance	2.0	20.9	27.3	6.2	0.7	16.5
Automobiles	9.9	-1.5	-11.8	-15.3	-16.1	-16.1

Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

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Asia Pacific Economic Research

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